Theories of Attribution

An introduction to how we explain the world around us — exploring **Correspondent Inference Theory** and **Causal Attribution Theory**, and how attitudes shape our everyday thinking and behaviour.

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Why Do People Behave the Way They Do?

Every day, we observe the actions of those around us and instinctively ask: *Why did they do that?* This mental process — searching for the causes behind behaviour — is at the heart of social psychology.

We Seek Explanations

Humans are natural sense-makers. We rarely accept behaviour at face value — we probe for underlying motives, traits, and circumstances.

This Process Is Called Attribution

Attribution is the cognitive process by which we assign causes to events and the actions of others — forming the basis of our social judgements.

It Shapes Everyday Decisions

Whether we blame, praise, trust, or avoid someone often comes down to the attributions we make — making this one of the most practical areas of psychology.

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What Is Attribution?

Attribution refers to the process of explaining the causes of behaviour and events. It answers the fundamental question: *"Why did this happen?"*

The Core Idea

When we observe someone acting in a certain way, our minds automatically search for an explanation. This mental reasoning process helps us understand, predict, and respond to the world around us.

Why It Matters

Attribution shapes how we perceive others' intentions and character. It influences our emotional responses, social relationships, and even our judgements in high-stakes situations such as classrooms, courtrooms, and workplaces.

Attribution is not always accurate — it is a **mental shortcut**, subject to bias and error.

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Types of Attribution

When explaining behaviour, we typically attribute causes to one of two broad categories — **internal** (within the person) or **external** (outside the person). Understanding this distinction is foundational to all attribution theories.

🧠 Internal (Dispositional)

The cause is located **within the person** — their personality, ability, intelligence, motivation, or effort.

Example: "She failed the exam because she didn't study hard enough."

🌍 External (Situational)

The cause is located **outside the person** — the environment, luck, task difficulty, or social pressure.

Example: "She failed the exam because it was unreasonably difficult."

ⓘ The same event can be explained in both ways — which attribution we choose reveals a great deal about our own biases and assumptions.

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Correspondent Inference Theory

JONES & DAVIS, 1965

Proposed by **Edward Jones** and **Keith Davis**, Correspondent Inference Theory explains how we draw conclusions about a person's underlying **traits and dispositions** directly from their behaviour — particularly when that behaviour appears to be **freely chosen and intentional**.

The Core Claim

We infer that a person's behaviour *corresponds* to a stable, internal trait. If someone acts aggressively, we conclude they are an aggressive person — not simply reacting to circumstances.

When It Applies

Correspondent inferences are strongest when behaviour is deliberate and chosen freely. Accidental or coerced behaviour tells us much less about who a person truly is.

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Key Factors in Correspondent Inference

Jones and Davis identified three critical factors that determine how confident we are in drawing a correspondent inference — that is, concluding that behaviour reflects a person's true character.

1

Choice

If the behaviour was **freely chosen** (not forced or expected), it is far more informative about personality. Freely chosen actions carry greater inferential weight.

2

Social Desirability

Uncommon or socially unexpected behaviour reveals more about a person. Acting in line with social norms tells us little — deviating from them tells us a great deal.

3

Non-Common Effects

When a chosen action has **unique outcomes** not achievable by alternatives, those effects pinpoint the true motive. The fewer the unique effects, the clearer the inference.

Example: A student who voluntarily chooses the hardest assignment — when easier ones were available — is likely inferred to be **hardworking and ambitious**.

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Kelley's Causal Attribution Theory

HAROLD KELLEY, 1967

Harold Kelley proposed that people approach the task of attribution much like **scientists** — systematically observing patterns of behaviour across different situations, people, and time to identify the most logical cause.

The Covariation Model

Kelley's framework, known as the **Covariation Model**, suggests that we attribute behaviour to whatever factor *covaries* most consistently with it. Just as a scientist looks for correlations in data, we look for patterns in behaviour before assigning a cause.

This model assumes we have access to multiple observations over time — making it a **rational, logical** approach to understanding human behaviour.

Key Insight

Unlike Correspondent Inference Theory, which focuses on a single act, Kelley's model emphasises **repeated patterns** across situations — making it especially powerful for explaining consistent behaviour.

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Kelley's Three Factors: The Covariation Model

Kelley proposed that we use three types of information — **Consensus**, **Consistency**, and **Distinctiveness** — to determine whether a cause is internal (the person) or external (the situation).

Consensus

Do **other people** behave the same way in the same situation? High consensus points to an external cause.

Consistency

Does this person behave this way **every time** the situation occurs? High consistency suggests a stable cause.

Distinctiveness

Does this person behave this way **only in this specific situation**? High distinctiveness suggests an external cause.

Classic Example: A student laughs at a teacher's joke. If *everyone* laughs (high consensus), *they always laugh* at this teacher (high consistency), and *only at this teacher* (high distinctiveness) → we make an **external attribution**: the teacher is genuinely funny.

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Attitude: Concept & Definition

PART 2: ATTITUDE

An **attitude** is a learned, relatively stable evaluation of a person, object, idea, or situation — expressed along a continuum from **very positive** to **very negative**. Attitudes are not innate; they are shaped by our experiences, culture, and social environment.

Evaluative in Nature

Attitudes involve a judgement — we are not neutral. We evaluate things as good or bad, desirable or undesirable, and these evaluations guide our responses.

Learned Through Experience

We acquire attitudes through direct experience, observation, and social influence. They can change over time — though strongly held attitudes are remarkably resistant to change.

Influences Behaviour

Attitudes predispose us to act in certain ways. A positive attitude towards exercise, for instance, makes it more likely we will actually engage in physical activity.

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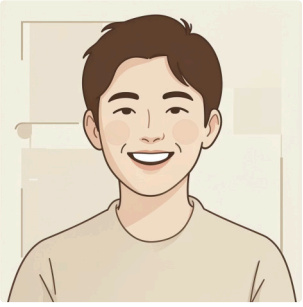
The Three Components of Attitude

Psychologists describe attitude as having three distinct but interconnected components — often called the **ABC Model**. Together, they capture the full picture of how we evaluate and respond to the world.

Cognitive Component

Our **beliefs and thoughts** about an object or idea. *"Regular exercise is good for my health"* — this belief forms the cognitive basis of the attitude.



Affective Component

Our **feelings and emotions** associated with the object. *"I genuinely enjoy exercising"* — this emotional response reinforces or shapes the attitude.

Behavioural Component

Our **actions and intentions** toward the object. *"I exercise three times a week"* — behaviour is the observable expression of the underlying attitude.

> Thank you for your attention! Understanding attribution and attitude gives us powerful tools to decode human behaviour — both in others and in ourselves.

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